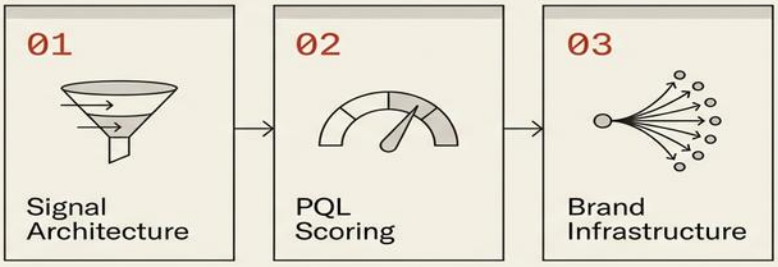
A PLG OPERATING FRAMEWORK

The PLG Framework for Developer Products

Three systems that convert free users into qualified pipeline.

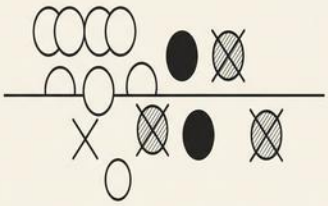


01

Signup Gate

Work email + company + stated use case.

Filters 40% of non-buyers before they cost you anything downstream.



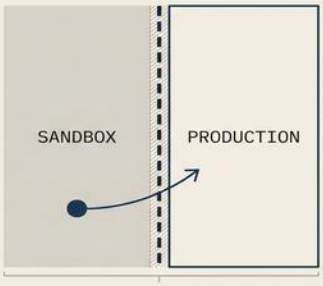
has_work_email | stated_use_case

02

Integration Boundary

Sandbox is frictionless. Production requires a verification step.

Where casual exploration becomes real commitment.



production_integration_date

integration_depth_score

03

Conversion Wall

What line: Usage limits plus feature gates.

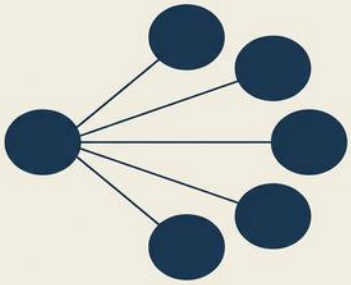
Why line: Tuned to convert growth trajectory, not cap adoption.

04

Team Expansion Gate

Collaboration behind paid tier. Invite limits on free.

One dev is an experiment. Five devs is an evaluation.



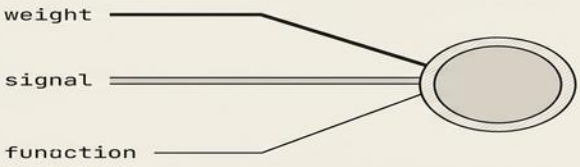
team_size

admin_engagement_score

Scoring for Production Dependency

The question every variable answers: is this user showing signs of production dependency plus enterprise need?

WEIGHTEDS



P2.01

P2.02

Variable Categories

PRODUCTION USAGE

40%

- api_calls_last_30d
- error_rate
- integration_points
- usage_consistency

ENTERPRISE INTENT

40%

- team_size
- sso_attempt
- usage_limit_proximity
- domain_firmographic

ENGAGEMENT

20%

- docs_depth
- community_participation
- support_ticket_quality
- pricing_page_visits

Editorial Infographic Panel

P2.03

Scoring Formula

PQL Score = (Production × 0.4) + (Enterprise × 0.4) + + (Engagement × 0.2)

IF score > 70 AND team_size ≥ 3 → Route to Sales

Start simple. Advanced variants split developer-led vs. top-down.

P2.04

Developer-Led

HIGH PRODUCTION USAGE + LOW ENTERPRISE SIGNALS

Route to DevRel. Nurture with technical content. Sales calls kill this motion.

Top-Down

ENTERPRISE SIGNALS + MODERATE USAGE

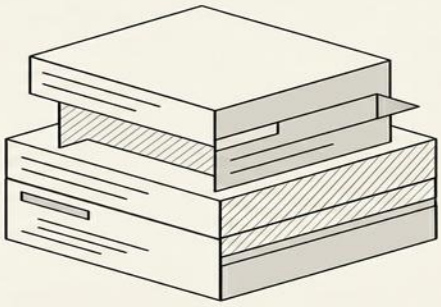
Route to Enterprise AE. Speed matters. Exec evaluations move fast or die.

1 One Technical Piece → Ten Developer Touchpoints

Build once. Distribute across every channel where developers discover tools.

GitHub as Primary Distribution

Developers trust code over copy. A repo with 500 stars is more credible than a case study.



SDKs · Example repos · Starter templates · Migration scripts · Debugging utilities

Three Paths to Pipeline

Path A — High-Quality PQL	Signup →	Integrate →	Scale usage →	Team invites →	Route to Sales
Path B — Low Signal	Signup →	Sandbox only →	No team →		Nurture, don't call
Path C — GitHub → Community → Enterprise	Repo discovery →	Team sprawl →	Director asks "what is this?" →		Inbound enterprise PQL

What to Measure

TOP OF FUNNEL
- Work-email signups
- Production integrations
- GitHub stars and forks

MIDDLE OF FUNNEL
- PQL-to-opportunity rate
- Time from PQL to close
- Developer-sourced leads

REVENUE HEALTH
- Expansion revenue
- PLG vs. sales-led CAC
- NRR by channel

DISTRIBUTION
- Repo engagement
- Content multiplier ratio
- Organic share of voice

Four Failure Modes

- ⊗ **Loose friction + aggressive PQL thresholds** → Phantom pipeline. Tighten signup, add enterprise signals.
- ⊗ **Tight friction + weak brand infrastructure** → Growth ceiling. Build the content engine.
- ⊗ **Strong usage signals + no conversion wall** → Permanently free users. Recalibrate limits and feature gates.
- ⊗ **B2B marketing tactics aimed at developers** → Credibility death. GitHub first. Marketing second.